

DESIGN FOR REAL PEOPLE

Playbook – Week 1

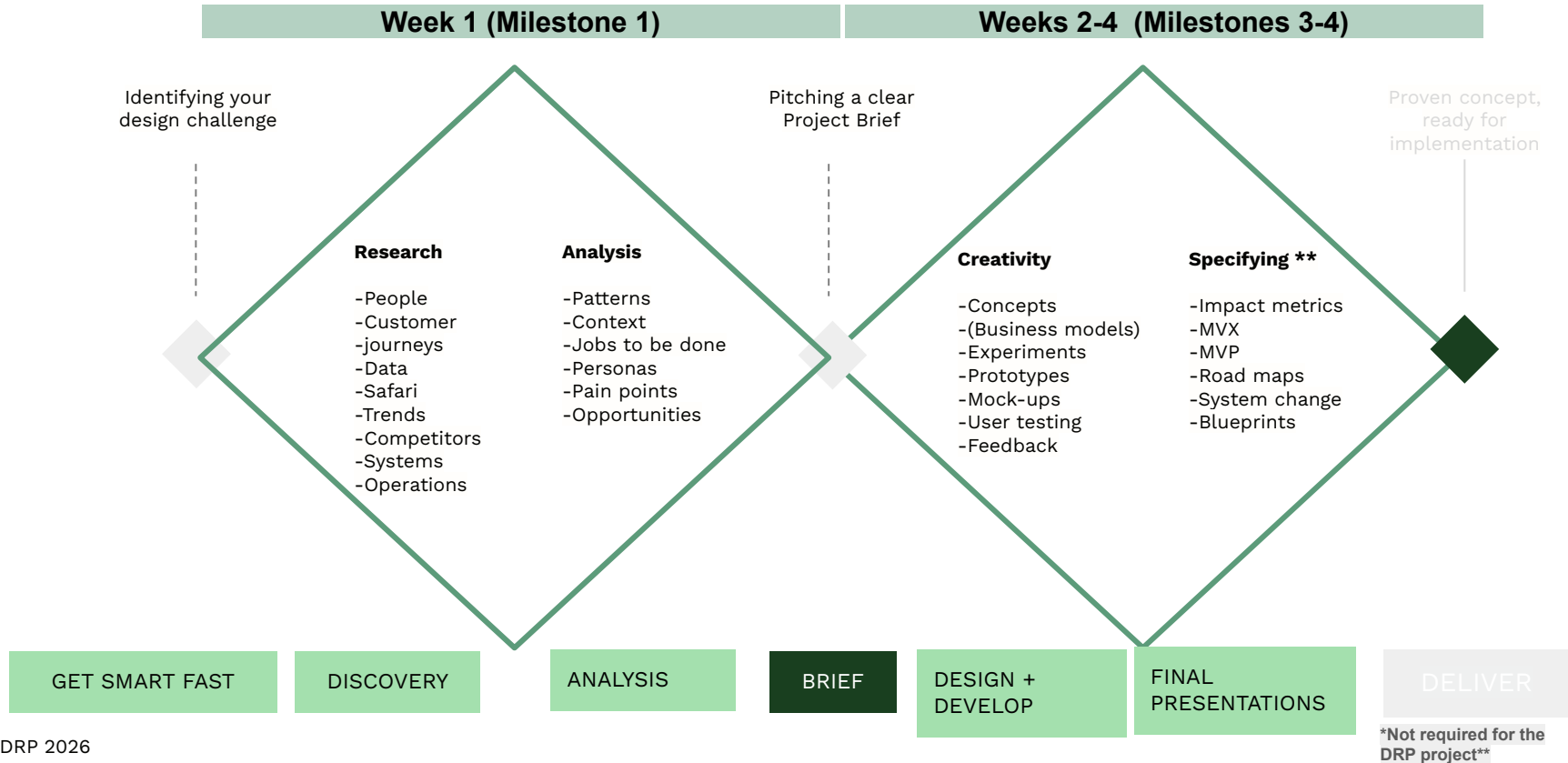


Royal College of Art

Imperial College
London

DRP 2026

4x weekly sprints until you reach the final presentation in June



This playbook is a live resource to support Week 1 of your DRP project

Project activities create a scaffold and practical guidance on what to do during Week 1 of your project

Templates and tools can be applied at different phases of your project to help you:

- find answers to your questions when you're exploring a problem/opportunity context,
- represent and visualise users and stakeholders, what they're doing, how they're feeling (frustrations and motivations)
- understand what your research is telling you as you synthesise and analyse your findings
- Communicate a compelling story for both your pitch

the playbook for Weeks 2 - 4 will be shared during Week 1

Week 1/Sprint 1

Getting started: Week 1/Sprint 1

Activity 1 - understanding what needs to be in your pitch

Activity 2 - choosing a topic and problem to focus on

Activity 3 - selecting a feasible problem to focus on

Activity 4 - drafting your research plan

Activity 5 - designing your research

Activity 6 - conducting fieldwork

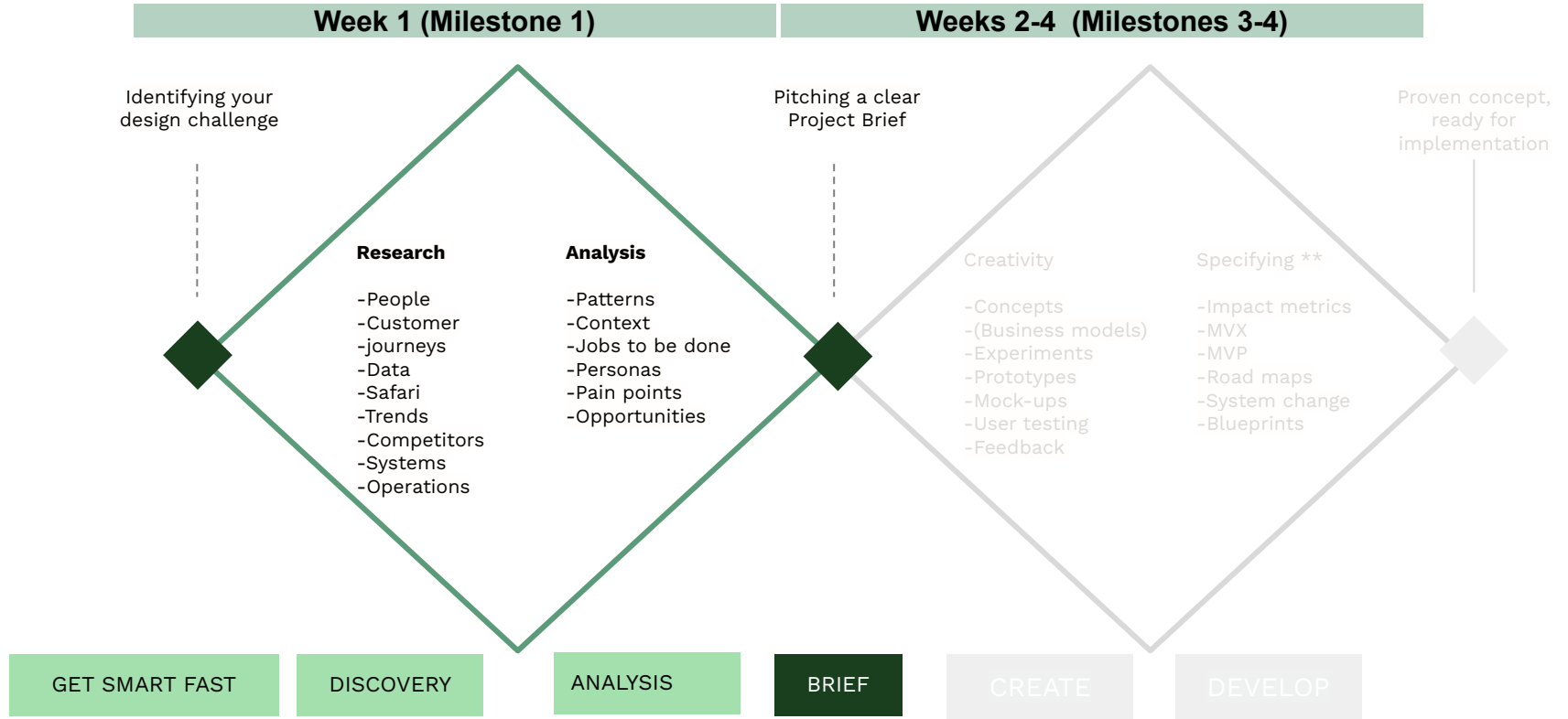
Activity 7 - analysing and making sense of your research findings

Activity 8 - developing a problem statement

Activity 9 - create a 'How might we..' question to set the direction of your project

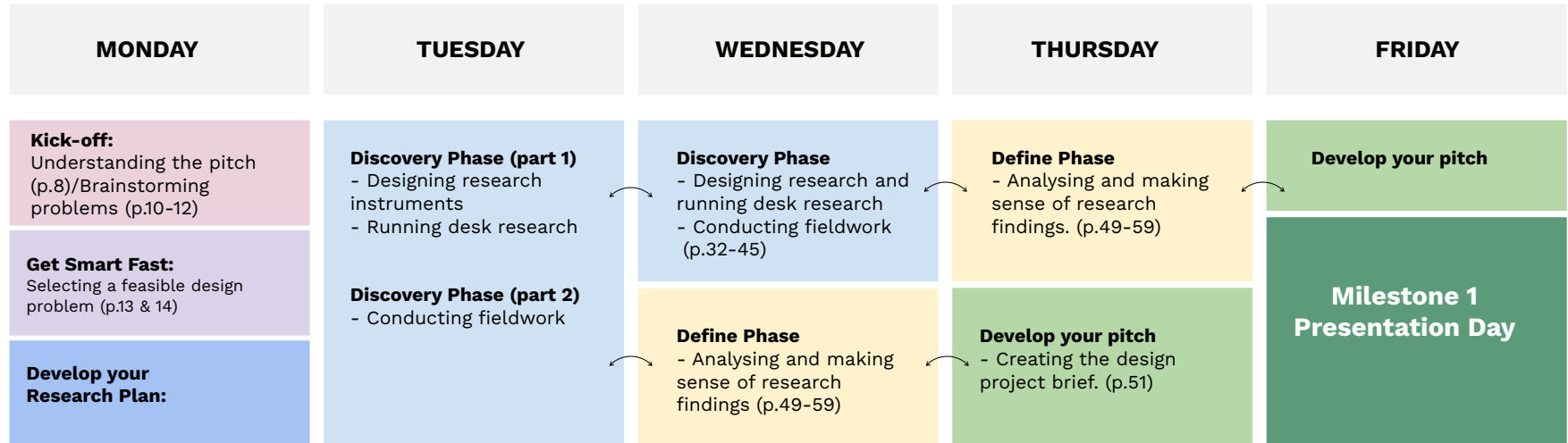
Activity 10 - develop and record your 3-minute pitch

Week 1/Sprint 1: you have just 1 week to sprint through the first diamond so planning effectively is key



Week 1/Sprint 1: plan each day to set yourselves up for a successful pitch

SPRINT 1 - WEEK 1



Activity 1 - Week 1/Sprint 1 - what do you need to include in your project pitch?

Before deciding on your topic, clarify what you need to present for Milestone 1

Here are some **key elements to keep in mind when drafting the PITCH**

Some of the design tools and frameworks used throughout the first diamond (discover and define phases) can be used to help you better communicate your process and how you understand a problem that surfaces. At the same time, they are not an end in themselves. They help you analyse, make sense of what's happening in a context and what actionable decisions you need to make to move forward

As you shape your brief, keep in mind how your learning informs and grounds how you're framing your chosen challenge



Context of the problem (Where / When / Wider conditions)

Describe the problem space, including the broader context in which it exists: place, time, industry/context dynamics, macro trends, local realities, etc. Keep it concrete rather than abstract. All problems are contextual.

Who is affected (Subject of the problem)

Identify the specific group or people affected by the problem. Avoid broad or vague terms such as “everyone.”

What is the problem (unmet need / difficulty)

Describe the problem statement clearly. Focus on the difficulty, friction, or unmet need rather than jumping too quickly to a solution.

Unwanted consequences (Why it matters)

Understand the negative impact the problem creates in people's lives and why it is important to address. This impact may be emotional, practical, social, environmental, or systemic. Keep it grounded in evidence.

Likely causes or contributing factors (Why it happens)

Identify the factors that may be creating, shaping, or worsening the problem. These are often the drivers, blockers, or conditions that design may need to respond to. Addressing only the consequences may relieve symptoms, but it is less likely to create lasting positive change.

Existing efforts or solutions (What is already being tried)

Describe the services, solutions, or interventions that already exist. Reflect on why they may be falling short or leaving gaps. This can help you identify a clearer opportunity space.

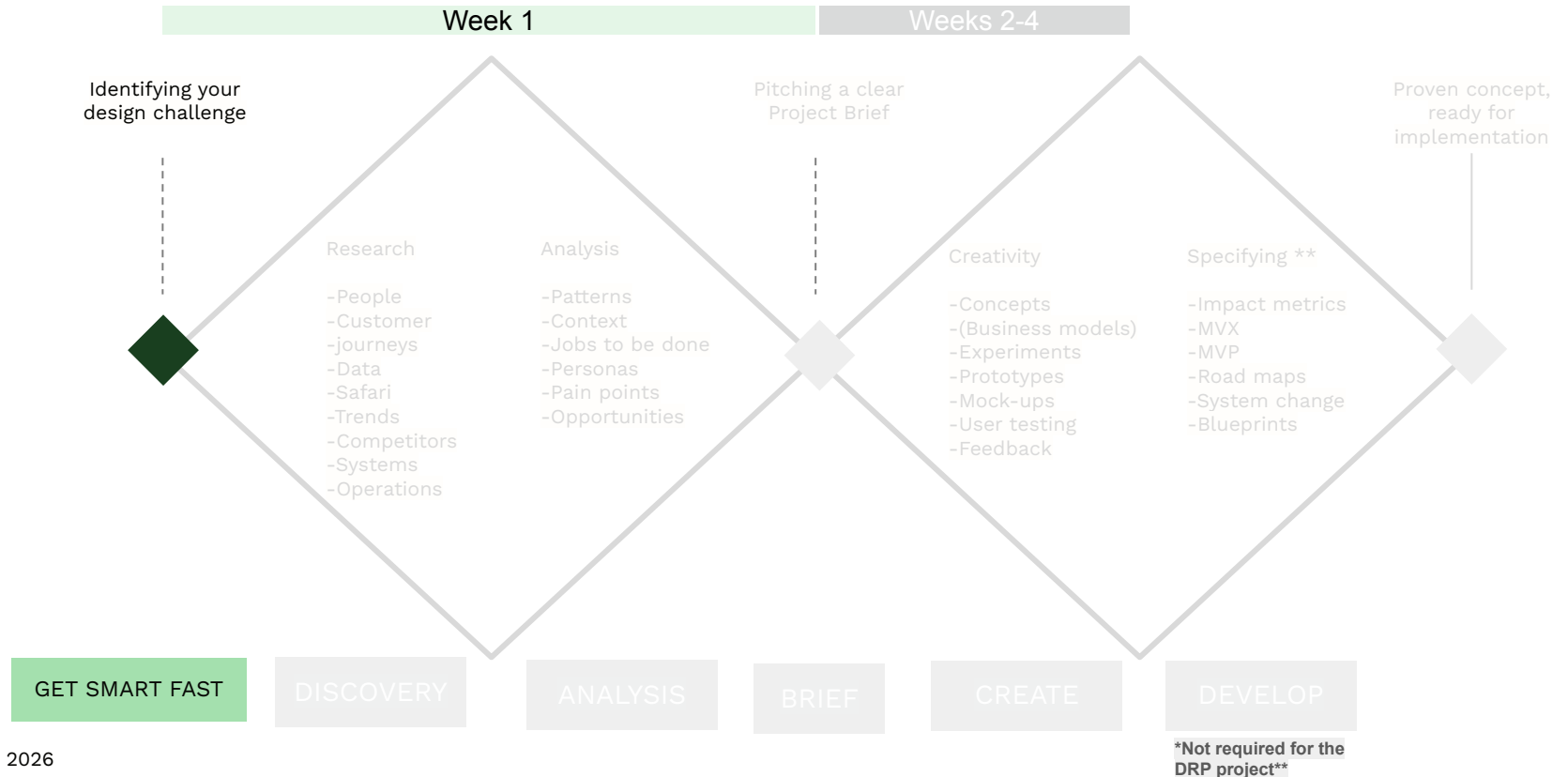
Stakeholder analysis (Who is involved and why they matter)

Keep the problem description relational and systemic by identifying the key actors around the issue. This may include people affected by the problem, people or organisations influencing the situation, people or organisations delivering services or support, and people or organisations setting rules, standards, or constraints.

Clear Problem Statement + HMW and design principle

Frame a clear How Might We question and, where possible, list the key design principle identified during research — both the whats and the how — to provide grounded direction for ideation.

Activity 2 - Week 1/Sprint 1: Choosing your project topic/context of a problem



Monday: find a good problem or opportunity to focus on for DRP



Week 1/Sprint 1/Activity 2

Find a good problem/opportunity to focus on for DRP

One way to begin is by **brainstorming possible problem areas** as a group. Start by thinking about situations, services, or experiences that feel frustrating, difficult, confusing, inefficient, or poorly designed.

At this stage, the aim is not to solve the problem, but to surface problems that may be worth exploring further.

Some trigger questions...

What feels frustrating, confusing, or badly designed in everyday life services, experiences, or products?

Where do users have to improvise or find workarounds because current experiences or services do not support them properly?

What problems keep coming up in your own experience, or in the experience of people around you, that feel worth exploring further?



When brainstorming problems with your group, try to describe each one using four **key elements: what is happening, what is the problem, who is affected, and why does it matter? Use desktop research to back this up...**

After mapping and discussing some topics you're interested in, vote for the most promising topic and problem for DRP



When brainstorming problems with your group, try to describe each one using four **key elements**: **what is happening**, **what is the problem**, **who is affected**, and **why does it matter?** Use desktop research to back this up...

Week 1/Sprint 1/Activity 3

At this stage, **you will need to work with your group to identify a problem — a design challenge.**

Using design tools, techniques, and frameworks, you will begin to understand and frame the problem, develop your project brief, and later shape a design solution that addresses that challenge.

Broadly speaking, defining a design challenge may involve identifying unmet needs or opportunities to create value for users, organisations, or society. This may involve rethinking services, or addressing a wider business, social, or environmental challenge. The topic and scope are up to you.

Setting up for success

Think strategically, Think critically.

As you begin discussing possible topics or problem areas, you could use these prompt questions to reflect on whether your choice feels workable and strong enough to build a project around.

Reflection prompts

Low confidence

Medium confidence

High confidence



Think about the scope

How confident are you that the problem has the right scope for the project? A problem too broad may require substantial research and iteration to narrow down. One too narrow may leave little room for exploration.

☐☐☐

Think about feasibility

Will you be able to reach users, professionals, experts, public information, and other relevant resources to understand the problem through research and later test your ideas within the timeframe?

☐☐☐

Think about familiarity

Do you, or does someone in your team, have some knowledge or experience of this topic? This can make it easier to move forward with greater confidence, speed, and depth.

☐☐☐

Think about interest

Is this a topic that genuinely interests and motivates your team? Will your curiosity and interest sustain you over the weeks, especially when the work becomes more complex or challenging?

☐☐☐

If most of your answers sit in **low confidence**, it may be worth reconsidering or reframing your chosen area. You can still move forward, but it will likely require more work.

If your answers sit mostly between **medium** and **high confidence**, you are likely in a good place to kick off.

If all your answers sit in **high confidence**, you are likely starting from a strong place.

Service Design RCA | Carolyn Runcie and Cecilia Santucho 2026

Some examples

Too Narrow

Students often do not know in advance what meals will be served in the university canteen, which can lead them to waste time going there only to find that the available options do not suit their preferences or needs.

How might we design a solution that lets students check in advance which meals are available in the university canteen each day?

Expanding questions:

- Is this a recurring issue affecting many students, or only a small subgroup in a particular situation?
- Is this single touchpoint the most meaningful issue within the broader student food experience on campus?
- What wider needs, behaviours, or frustrations shape how students access food on campus?
- What wider needs, behaviours, or frustrations shape students' lives and routines around food — planning, shopping, cooking, buying prepared food, and making day-to-day food choices?

Too Broad

The NHS in England is facing significant workforce shortages, with 100K+ vacancies recorded in 2025, including 25.5K vacancies in nursing roles and almost 7.3K in medical ones (1). Staffing shortages affect the NHS's capacity to deliver the quantity of care people need, while also impacting staff wellbeing and the system's ability to reform.

How might we solve the shortage of doctors and nurses in the NHS?

Scoping questions:

- What part of the NHS services are most concerned: hospitals, primary care, ER, etc?
- Which workforce group is most affected: nurses, doctors, GPs, etc?
- What are to be the main drivers of the problem: recruitment, retention, training, workload, staff wellbeing, pay, or something else?
- Which patient groups are most affected?
- Is the problem more acute in particular geographic areas?
- What consequences is this shortage generating across the wider system?
- Which parts of the problem could be addressed by a design intervention, and which would require wider policy or structural reform?
- What kind of research would be needed to better understand the ecosystem and identify a more specific opportunity space?

Monday: draft an actionable research plan

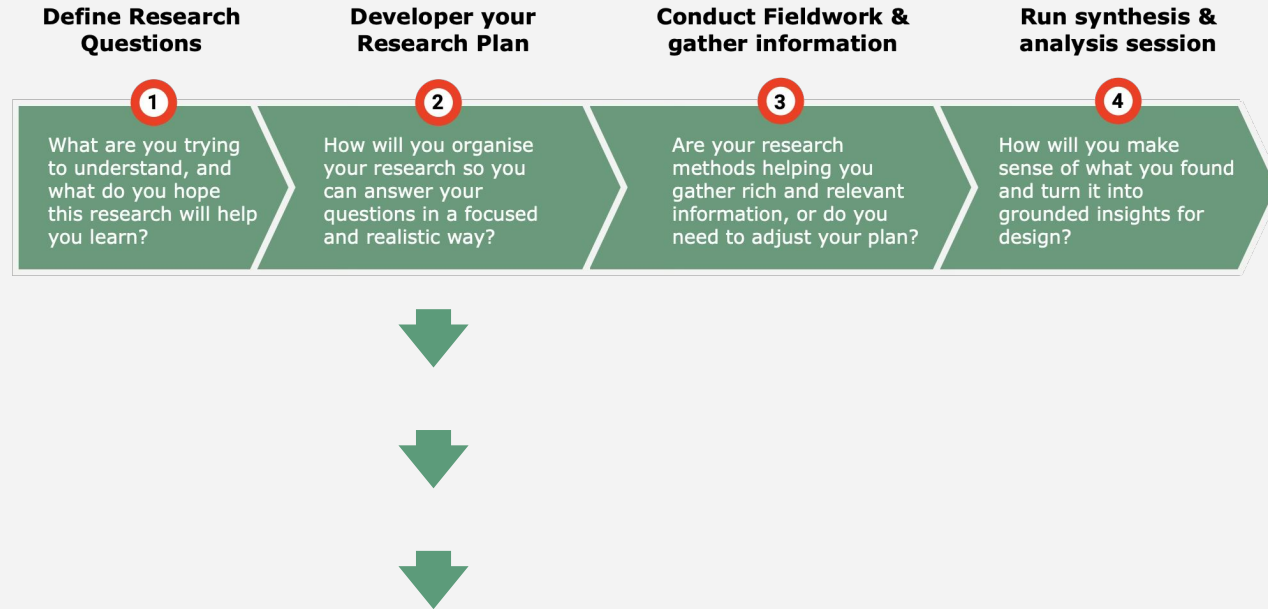
Now that you've chosen your topic, you should set out an actionable research plan that helps you understand that problem context more deeply, helping you to understand the goal of the project - what is the real problem, who is affected by the problem and who will continue to work with throughout your problem.

Week 1/Sprint 1/Activity 4

Your research process

Now that you've agreed on the focus of your project, start to discover more about this context: **developing a research plan can help you organise your exploratory work** by clarifying your research questions and the methods and tools that will help you answer those questions. →

A thoughtful research plan will support your group in making more intentional choices, staying focused on what you need and want to learn, and using your time wisely.



Gather insights

The **Discover stage** is the **beginning of your research process**. To start, ask yourself who is your cast of characters? What situations are they currently in? What are their relationships? How do they interact and what challenges do they face? And who is the leading character in your story? While you may have some ideas about the answers to these questions now, these are your hypotheses that should be validated through your research process in this stage of work.

In the Discover phase you want to expand your research, exploring a wide range of areas to ensure you see the full picture. Speak to people, ask questions about their situation, what do they already do to solve their problems? Who supports them? What tools do they use? Document this as you go and gain consent from your participants.

Your actionable research plan

Please bring this to the clinic hours to help you share your focus and approach



Initial problem statement

What is the problem area you want to explore through research?

Target-user & key stakeholder

whose perspectives are essential to capture and understand?

Research questions

what do you need to learn and why?

Research method

what method you plan to use to empathies with your user and their context?

Fieldwork participants

Considering potential constraints (time, participants or proxies are you planning

Research Instruments

What materials you need to prepare to carry out the fieldwork (interview guides, observation prompts, surveys, etc)?

Timelines

When will preparation, fieldwork, synthesis, and analysis happen?

Responsibilities

Who in your group will lead each part of the fieldwork, and how will tasks be coordinated?



Initial problem statement

What is the problem area you want to explore through research?

Many students who move to London for university struggle to find accommodation before starting their studies.

Target-user & key stakeholder

whose perspectives are essential to capture and understand?

Main target: International and out-of-town students. **Other SHs involved in the decision-making process:** University accommodation teams, student support services, private accommodation providers, letting agents, possibly parents.

Research questions

what do you need to learn and why?

Illustrative Qs:

- How do students currently search for accommodation before or after moving to London?
- What kind of accommodation are they looking for? What do they need, and what are their decision drivers?
- What platforms and services are they using to find accommodation?
- What information, support or advice do they need and rely on during the search?
- What barriers and pain points are they facing?
- How do students decide which listings, areas or sources of information they can trust?
- Who supports them during the search process, and how?
- What are the consequences if students cannot find accommodation that meets their needs?

Research method

what method you plan to use to empathise with your user and their context?

Illustrative:

- **Interviews with students** who moved to London for university, to understand what information, support or advice they needed and relied on during the search.
- A **short survey** to identify common patterns, barriers and decision-making factors.
- **Desk research or a service safari** focused on university accommodation guidance, private rental options, student housing platforms, and the service offering.
- **Journey mapping** to understand the steps students go through when searching for accommodation.
- **Stakeholder interviews** with accommodation or student support staff, if accessible.

Fieldwork participants

Considering potential constraints (time, accessibility), what participants or proxies are you planning to engage with?

Illustrative:

- 3–5 international and out-of-town students who moved to London in the last year.
- Survey 10–20p undergraduate students.
- 1–2 university staff members involved in accommodation, student support guidance.
- Possible constraints: availability, recruitment time, students' willingness to discuss housing stress.

Research Instruments

What materials you need to prepare to carry out the fieldwork (interview guides, observation prompts, surveys, etc)?

Illustrative:

- Interview discussion guide for student and key stakeholders.
- Short survey form.
- Participant recruitment message.
- Journey mapping, AEIOU and photo diary templates to capture the accommodation search process.

Timelines

When will preparation, fieldwork, synthesis, and analysis happen?

Illustrative:

- **Preparation:** Tuesday morning
- **Fieldwork:** Tuesday afternoon and Wednesday
- **Synthesis:** Wednesday afternoon and Thursday

Responsibilities

Who in your group will lead each part of the fieldwork, and how will tasks be coordinated?

Illustrative:

- Two people draft discussion guide and survey.
- One person coordinates recruitment, logistics.
- Two people conduct student interviews and take notes.
- One person runs desk research.

Tuesday-Wednesday: design your research

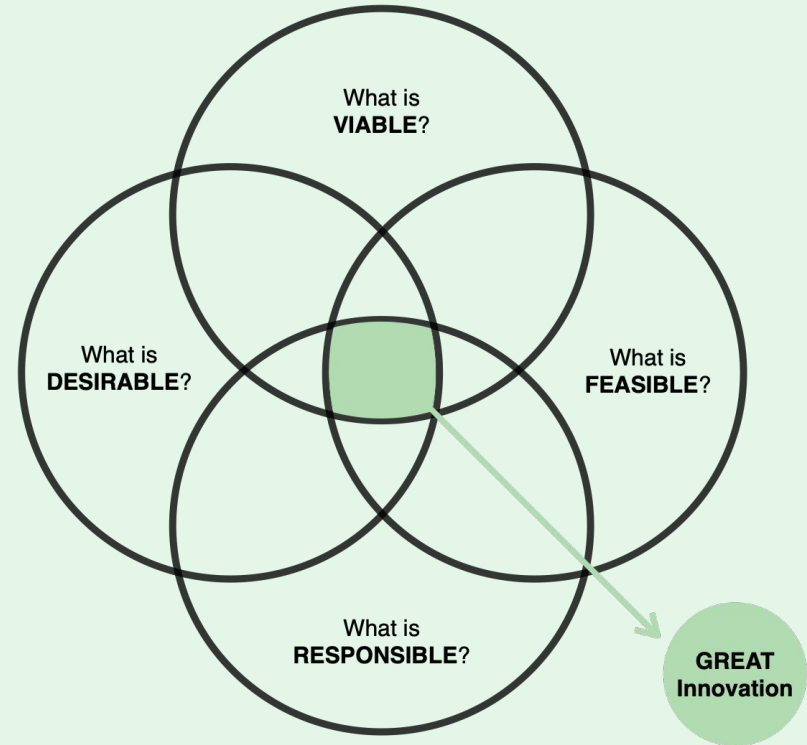


Week 1/Sprint 1/Activity 5

An approach that puts people's needs and what they value at the centre of your innovation process, examines people's lives, what they actually do and what you need to do to generate new value for them.

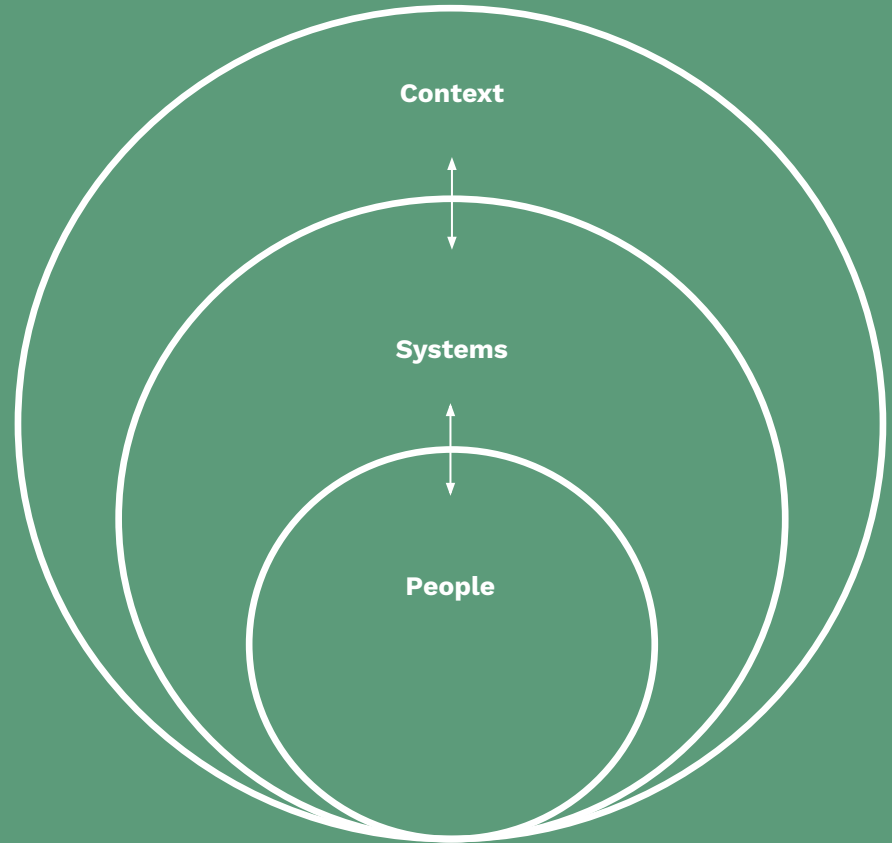


Designing a value-driving digital product or service is not just about assembling a collection of features, but about coherently designing and integrating its different parts into a meaningful experience that delivers responsible value for users, the given organization, and broader society.

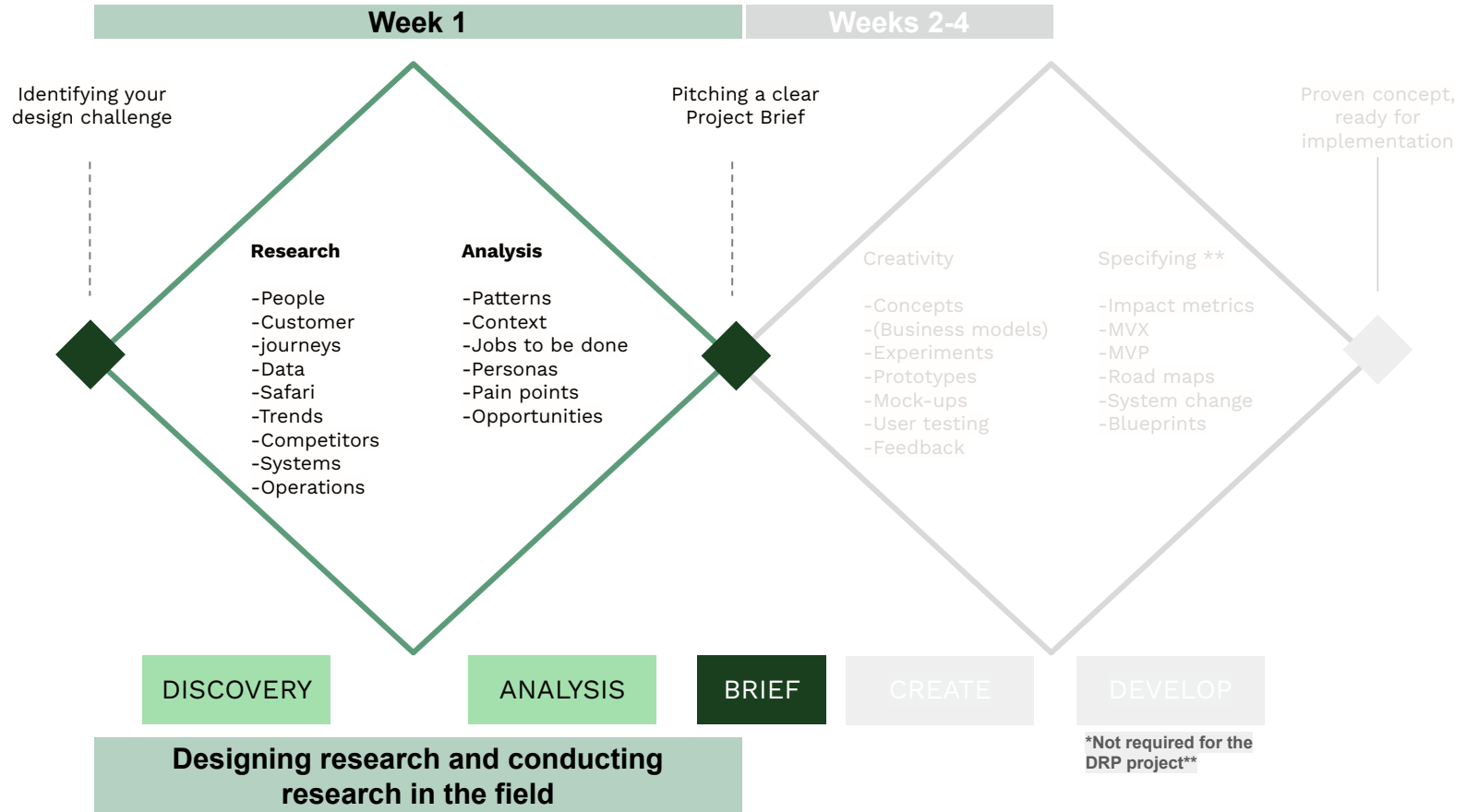


The Discovery phase is about exploring the challenge from **multiple perspectives** to **build a richer understanding of the problem at hand**.

In design, this means looking beyond the surface of an issue to better understand the people involved, the ecosystem around it, and the wider conditions in which it exists.



Week 1/Sprint 1/Activity 5 + Activity 6



Week 1/Sprint 1/Activity 5

Designing your research

After discussing your topics as a group and having explored the who, what, when, why, vote for the one that is the most promising for DRP. Carry out desk research, a stakeholder map, a plan of how to contact stakeholders for interviews, a list of places to visit and some processes you would like to observe. You can be as creative as you like with your research methods.

Design starts at this stage, design your research. Think about the best ways to engage your participants. What tasks could you ask them to do that would give insight?

Design your questions - What you need to understand that you currently do not?

Design your method - in person zoom, what preparation do you want to give the interview participants?

Design your tools - in person paper conversational tools, or online Miro or Figma versions? Is there any information you would like participants to send? Would you like to see your participants perform certain tasks? What is the best way to find out in-depth information?

Design your research library = How are you storing and sharing your data? How will you make it easy to access when designing?

Remember: Design research is about finding out information that will inform your design. Keep asking yourself when conducting research 'do you have enough information to design with? Can you make informed decisions? Or am I still guessing?' You can change your interview questions in the moment to gain greater understanding. It can open up new research avenues in your desk research.

Template and tools

On the following pages are a range of templates and tools to use during your project

- eg a persona may be a good way to visualise who your target audience is,
- a stakeholder map may help you communicate who else is part of your chosen context and understanding the relationships;
- a journey map may help you visualise someone's current experience in your chosen context - you could use this to test your thinking with users/stakeholders etc

Desktop research

Statistics - academic papers, commercial studies and consumer insights reports.

Competitor analysis - what is the current best practice in the space you are aiming to design for? Where are the gaps?

Blogs, social media, forums - indirect user insights. People discussing their experiences and opinions.

Use desk research whilst you are waiting to organise user interviews, start immediately

Desktop research can progress your thinking around a subject and enable you to ask more insightful questions in your interviews

Desk research can provide qualitative data to combine with your quantitative data for richer insights.

Field research

User interviews - Interviews with stakeholders. Asking questions to gain direct insight into how people feel. Can be in person or online.

Observations - observe people, interactions, decisions. See what people actually do and compare with what they say.

Walk throughs - experience the whole product/service journey yourself. Try and experience it from the perspective of your stakeholders.

Field research is essential. It allows you to gain in-depth understanding of the experiences of different stakeholders.

It also allows you, the researcher to observe processes and decisions first-hand, objectively.

Tools and templates to help you answer some of your research questions

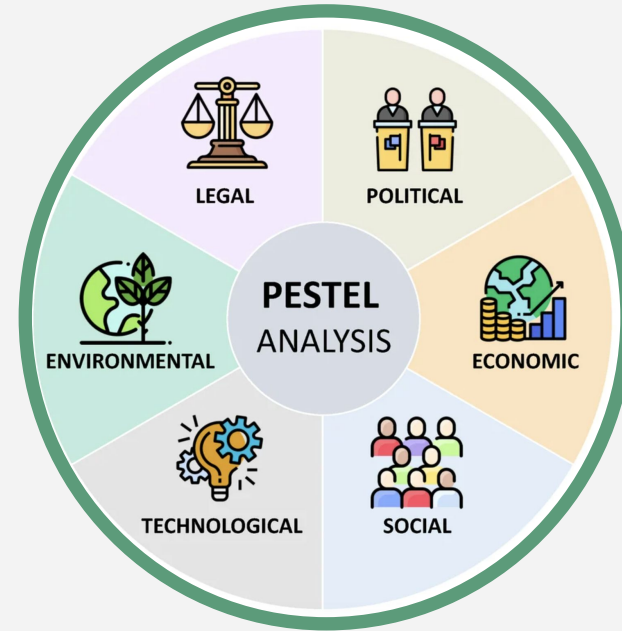
Understanding the context

All problems are contextual.

Understanding the context of your problem means looking at the where, the when, and the broader conditions that shape people's experiences and the system in which the problem exists. This might include technological change, industry dynamics, macro-trends, place-based realities, and wider social, economic, cultural, or environmental conditions.

Useful tools and activities:

desk research, trends analysis, PESTEL analysis, etc



PESTEL is a framework for analysing the broader external context around a problem. It helps you identified and interrogate diverse factors that could be influencing or shaping the challenge you are working on.

Tools and templates to help you answer some of your research questions



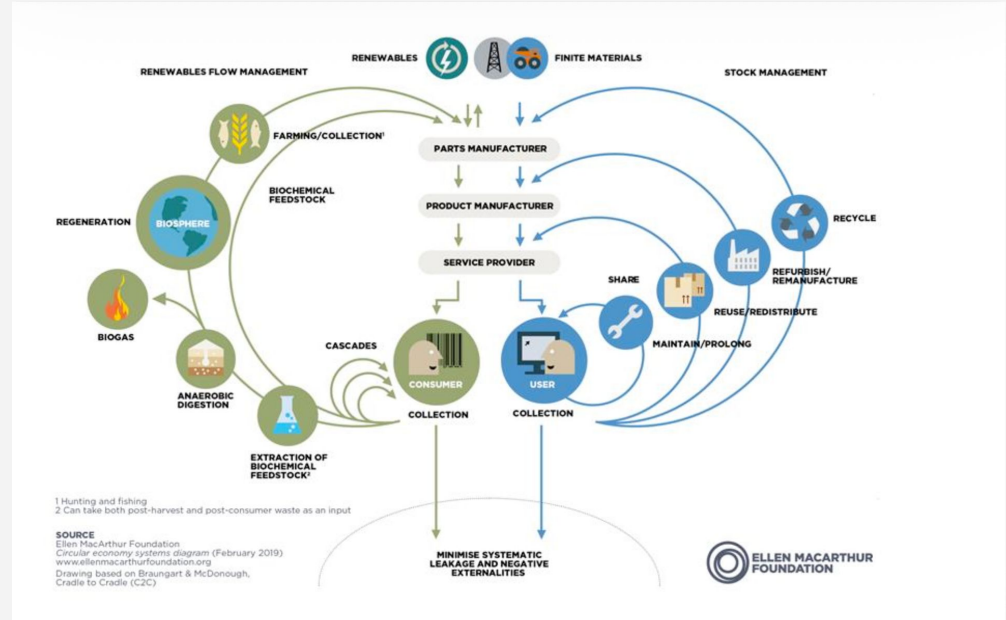
Understanding the system

Problems are systemic.

Understanding the ecosystem means identifying the key actors, relationships, processes, dependencies, and incentives that shape the problem space. This includes looking at organisations, stakeholders, other services, value chains, or adjacent systems (regulatory, technological, etc), understanding how they interact and shape one another, where tensions or gaps exist, and how value is currently created, delivered, or blocked.

Useful tools and activities:

Ecosystem map, stakeholder map, service blueprint, competitor analysis, etc.



Tools and templates to help you answer some of your research questions



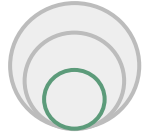
Understanding the people

Get to know your users, understand their **contexts** and the **challenges** they face. This can be done through interviews, workshops, through asking them to use early stage prototypes, or simply conversations. Really listen to what they have to tell you. They are the expert in their situation. Gain consent for their participation and documentation in your project.

Who are they? What do you know about them? What do you know about what they are trying to do? What challenges are they facing? Why is it a problem for them? What are their needs? How are they currently managing this issue?



Tools and templates to help you answer some of your research questions



PLAN YOUR RESEARCH - user interview

The overall aim of a user interview is to gain deeper understanding of a person's experience of a situation.

Tips

- Introduce yourself and the project
- Provide a warm welcome. Explain there are no right or wrong answers.
- Breathe and practice active listening.
- Ask interviewees about specific moments in the past, not imaginary moments in the future.
This is often best achieved with a conversational prompt tool.
- Ask open-ended questions.
- Ask follow-up questions such as why

Before the interview

Plan your questions, be clear about which areas you are looking to find out about. Design your questions so they are actually answerable. Test the interview questions on friends and iterate if needed. Plan how you will record responses and share with the group.

During the interview

Keep the conversation on topic. Keep thinking, do I understand well enough to design with the information in that answer? If not, ask more questions to understand.

After the interview

Write down the key takeaways immediately after the interview.

Process the interview into useful quotes that are in an accessible, shareable format.

Tools and templates to help you answer some of your research questions



When you have developed a strong understanding of your key character's needs and their contexts, you can create personas that capture the key insights and criteria you need to keep in mind as you work.

Persona 2		
Who?  Name: Gender: Age: Interests? Dreams? Where does he/she lives? How is his/her daily life? Knowledge? Skills?	Needs / Pains Jobs to be done?	Goals / Motivations What are the benefits he/she is looking for?

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Tools and templates to help you answer some of your research questions

When you have understood more about your key character and other cast members and their situations through first-hand research, try to map what you have learnt about their experiences. What does this tell you about the challenges they face and what support would benefit them?

Empathy Map



Tools and templates to help you answer some of your research questions



Journey mapping

A customer journey map describes each stage of a process a person (customer, citizen) goes through during their experience of the product or service.

Map how the customer is experiencing the product or service in the context you have defined.

Map out the journey over time and capture the key moments across all channels of delivery.

What is your key character currently experiencing in the context you're focusing on?

Journeys

Julia, 34
Mother of 8 year-old son
& housewife

"I like going to the market, because there I can talk to the producers."

	BEFORE				DURING						AFTER					
Stages	Aware	Plan Food	Consider Store	Depart	Enter Store	Browse	Select	Wait	Check Out	Depart	Arrive	Stock	Prepare	Cook	Eat	Trash & Recycle
Doing	Sees lacking ingredients for meals. Big Sunday shopping at the market.	Thinks about diversity, shortlist on iPhone.	Organic & healthy: market or Waitrose.	Goes with her boy, takes the list.	Grabs the basket and takes out the list, looks after her boy.	Follows the list. At the market, talks to producers. Watches her son.	Checks and ticks the list, compare products.	Distracts her boy.	Pays by card. No self-checkout. Involves her boy.	Carries the bags and her boy helps her.	Put the bags in the kitchen and takes care of the boy.	Sorts everything, boy helps her a bit.	Chops, boils etc.	Tries if it's good.	Ask for son's and husband's opinion. Talk, laugh, family time.	Recycles carefully.
Emotional Journey																
Opportunities	Help her plan the shopping and meals by showing what she already has in the kitchen and suggesting recipes matching her and her family's tastes and needs.					The store could be a place where people can share and socialize with others.		Children are demanding a lot of attention, parents could get help in watching their children so their shopping can be more effective.					Involve her son in the preparing and cooking.			



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Tools and templates to help you answer some of your research questions

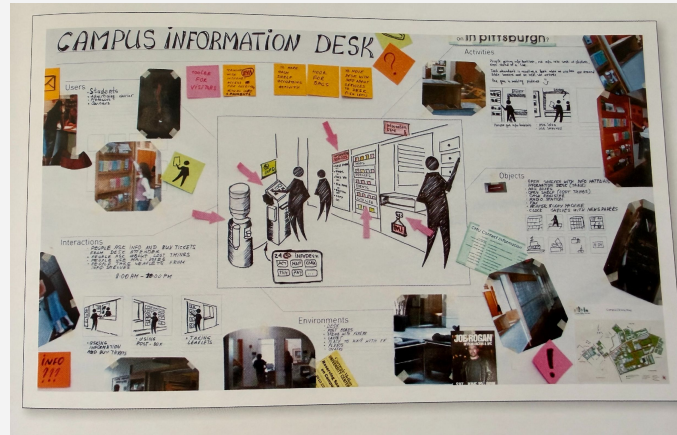


AEIOU is a framework that helps you carry out the fieldwork observations in a more structured way.

It invites you to look at five connected dimensions of an experience — Activities, Environment, Interactions, Objects, and Users — that need to be understood as interrelated parts of the given situation or experience that you are analysing.

The AEIOU framework can also be used alongside other research materials, such as photos, field notes, interview insights, or sketches, to help make sense of your observations.

Activities	Environment	Interactions	Objects	Users
Think about: - What are people doing or trying to do? - What actions, tasks, or routines can you observe?	Think about: - What is happening in the surrounding space? - How does the environment support, shape, or limit what people do? - How people are using the environment?	Think about: - Who or what are people interacting with? - What kinds of exchanges, responses, or behaviours can you notice?	Think about: - What tools, artefacts, or physical elements are involved? - How are these objects being used, adapted, or worked around?	Think about: - Who are the different people involved? - What roles, needs, or behaviours seem to shape their experience?

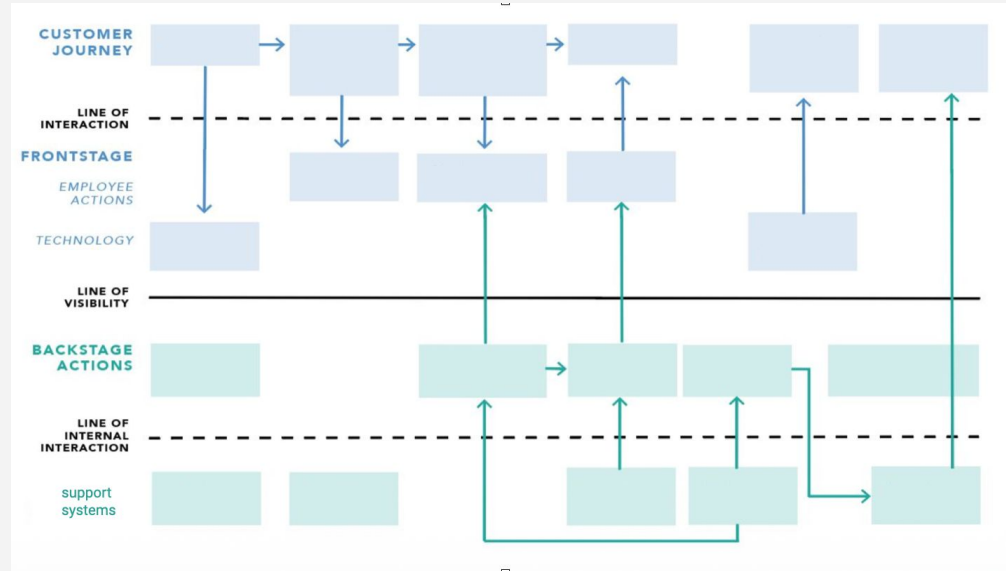


Tools and templates to help you answer some of your research questions

Blueprints

A service blueprint is a visual map of how a service works. It is **useful for understanding existing services** from a systemic perspective because it brings together the user experience and the organisational perspective, making visible the multiple processes, resources, and systems that must work together for a service to function: operational processes, digital systems, staffing arrangements, data flows, governance, compliance requirements, and other enabling structures

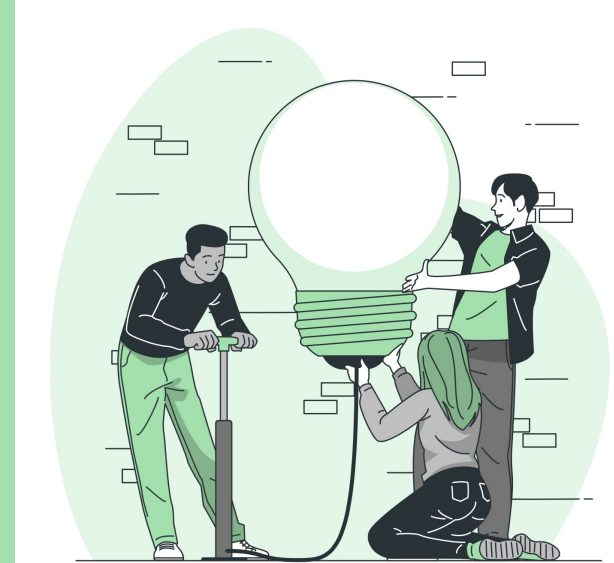
Besides providing a holistic view and understanding of a service, this actionable and analytical exercise can help you identify challenges, tensions, and opportunities across the service.



Tuesday–Wednesday: conduct your fieldwork

Using research instruments from your research plan to understand more about the problem by engaging with the relevant people eg interview guides. Reflect on how you will record the feedback, share it with your team, and then analyse and make sense of it

Wednesday-Thursday: analyse and make sense of your research findings



Process your research. Synthesise your observations and all of the information you gathered. Find the core problems. Focus down to a key problem to solve.

Do not start this phase unless you have found out new and surprising things about your topic. If you only have observations that you could have predicted before conducting the research, go back, find out more.

Week 1/Sprint 1/Activity 7

INSIGHTS - Post-it note Affinity mapping method

Affinity Diagram: Affinity mapping helps process your interviews, sort your findings, and identify insights in your data.

Step 1: Gather all of your data in one place and write down all research / facts / thoughts / ideas on the topic onto the post-it notes.

Step 2: You will find some post-it notes that are similar to each other or on the same topic. Combine them together.

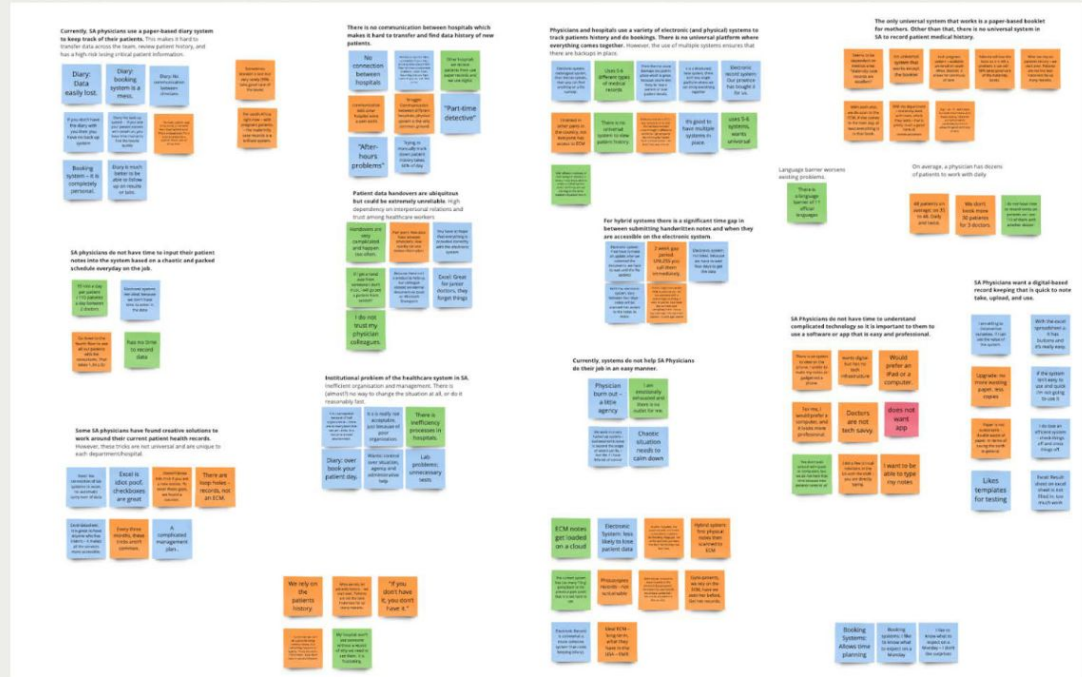
Step 3: Summarise each category in one sentence statements.



INSIGHTS - Post-it note Affinity mapping method

Step 4: After your interviews, put down a fact from the research (whether thought, opinion, interesting fact) on a post-it note).

Step 5: Then cluster the post-it notes in categories where they are similar. This will reveal user insights and themes of your research.



INSIGHTS - Post-it note Affinity mapping method

Step 6: Afterwards, build a 1 sentence statement of the cluster so we understand the insight.



Currently, SA physicians use a paper-based diary system to keep track of their patients. This makes it hard to transfer data across the team, review patient history, and has a high-risk losing critical patient information.

Diary:
Data
easily lost.

Diary:
booking
system is a
mess.

Diary: No
communication
between
clinicians

Sometimes
booklet is lost but
very rarely (99%
take good care of
the book)

If you don't have
the diary with
you then you
have no back up
system

Diary: No back up
system – If you lose
your patient stickers
with details on, you
have little chance to
find the results
quickly

- We make a photo copy
of my notes, or we write
her a short referral note.
This is a repeat scan. Put it
in an envelope for a
patient. Those sort of
things help.

For south Africa
right now – with
pregnant patients
– the maternity
case records is a
brilliant system.

Booking
system – it is
completely
personal.

Diary is much
better to be
able to follow
up on results
or tabs.

Define the right problem

With broad, exploratory research undertaken, the Define stage is where you can synthesise what you have found, ask what it means for your project and the problem/s you want to solve. What did you find in your initial research? What surprised you? What was as you expected? Is the leading character still who you thought it would be? Are the relationships between people the same as you thought or different? Map these things out.

Identify the complexities of the situations, the relationships between people, the timeline of events and where the challenges lie. Look at the quotes from the people you have spoken to, identify the pain points in the empathy maps you have created. Be clear about the issues the different characters face. From all of this work, the objective of this stage is to find the key issue your project needs to address and to be able to define the problem you are going to solve.

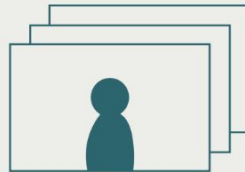
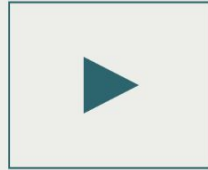
INSIGHTS - Multimedia Miro/Figma

By using online collaboration tools like Miro, it is possible to build up multimedia insights incorporating, photos and videos and links to web pages with you quotes. You can use the affinity mapping Post-it method to analyse, and then present all the data associated to make sure you have not mis-analysed any of it.

“ _____ ”

“ _____ ”

“ _____ ”



INSIGHT

Headline

Description

What is the broader insight, why do you think this?

Observations

What have you seen or heard that led you to this insight?

Implications and opportunities

what does this mean and what could you do to solve the problem/ enhance the interaction. Is there a design brief?



Templates and tools to define the problem well

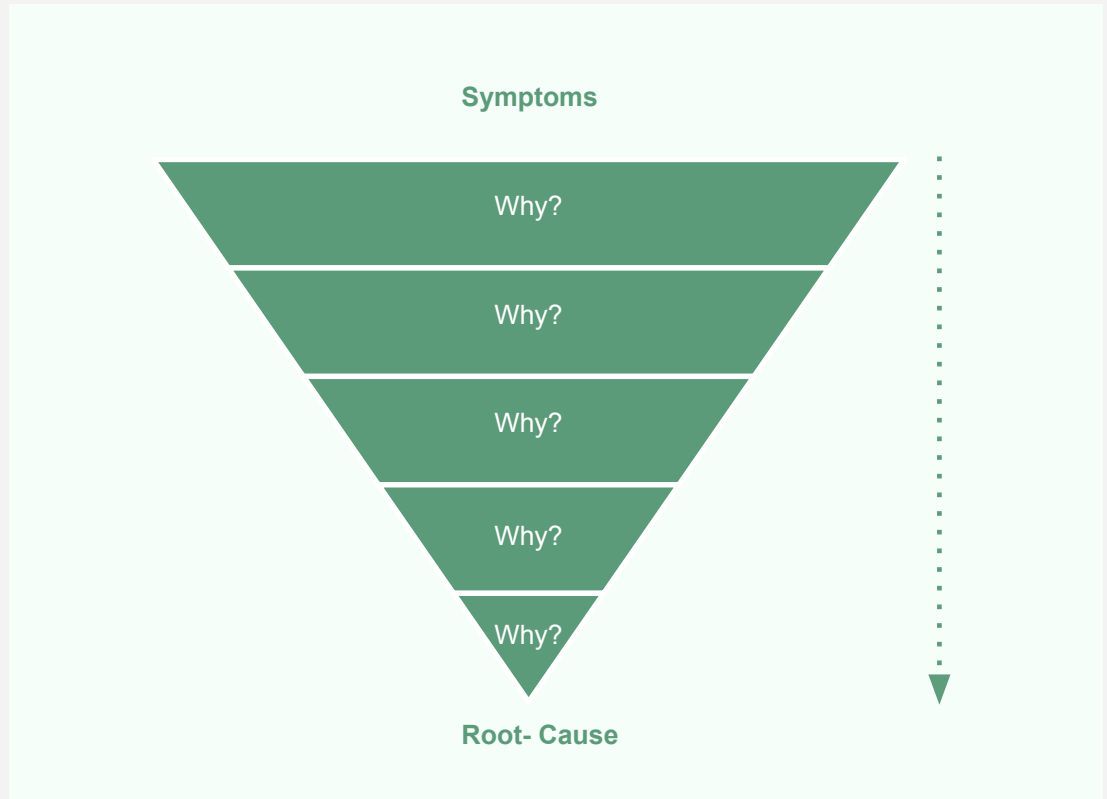
Tools and templates to help you analyse and make sense of your findings

The **5 Whys** is an iterative root-cause Interrogative technique used to move beyond a visible problem and explore what may be causing it.

During the define stage, it is useful because it helps teams avoid framing the problem only at the level of symptoms. Instead of stopping at what is immediately visible, it encourages you to unpack underlying causes, drivers, and blockers, and identify patterns that may need to be addressed.

The 5 Whys can also be useful:

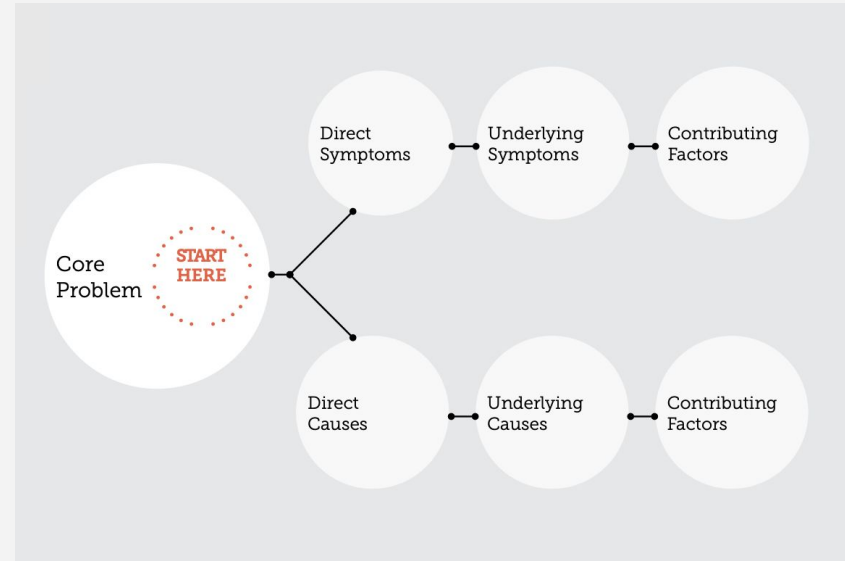
- **during interviews or user testing**, to gently probe beyond a first answer and better understand motivations
- **during team discussions**, to challenge assumptions and make the group's reasoning more explicit



Tools and templates to help you analyse and make sense of your findings

The **Cause Diagram** is A Causes Diagram is **another root-cause analysis tool that can help you organise and make sense of the insights** and information gathered during research, especially when working with complex problems. It helps you **identify the direct and indirect causes shaping an issue, and distinguish them from its consequences or symptoms.**

This matters because what is immediately visible is not always what is driving the problem. While some interventions may relieve symptoms, more lasting change often requires addressing one or more underlying causes. This can support a clearer understanding of the problem and help identify more meaningful points of intervention.



DIY-Toolkit. Nesta & Rockefeller Foundation.

Week 1/Sprint 1/Activity 8

A **problem/opportunity statement**

describes the issue you want to address. It helps concisely frame what is happening, for whom, why it is happening (main drivers/blockers), and why it matters (consequences/impact).

There are many different ways to write a problem statement, but it should always be focused, evidence-based, and grounded in research findings.

Problem statement structure

[User] is trying to [goal / task], but [barrier / blocker], which leads to [negative consequence].

nngroup

Example

Many international and out-of-town students are trying to find accommodation that feels safe, affordable, and well connected when moving to London for university, but they often have limited knowledge of the local area, little time to search, and uncertainty about which sources or listings they can trust, which leads them to make rushed decisions based on incomplete information, often ending up in accommodation that does not suit their needs and, in most cases, resulting in relocation within the first year.

Hypothetical case for educational purposes only

Week 1/Sprint 1/Activity 9

“How might we” is a trigger to define concepts around the jobs to be done and user stories. By answering the question HMW you can generate many different types of solution or features that solve the need and provide different ways to add value to your stakeholders.

The How Might We (HMW) question **reframes the problem as an opportunity for design exploration and ideation**, helping the team shift from understanding the problem to opening up possible responses. It is usually more open-ended and solution-oriented.

Example

Many international and out-of-town students are trying to find accommodation that feels safe, affordable, and well connected when moving to London for university, but they often have limited knowledge of the local area, little time to search, and uncertainty about which sources or listings they can trust, which leads them to make rushed decisions based on incomplete information, often ending up in accommodation that does not suit their needs and, in most cases, resulting in relocation within the first year.

How Might We...?

HMW help international and out-of-town students better understand different areas of London before choosing accommodation?

♥ Understanding the area

HMW help students make more confident and informed accommodation decisions before arriving in London for university?

♥ Making the decision

HMW help students identify accommodation options that feel trustworthy, affordable, and suitable for their everyday needs?

♥ Assessing the option

Thursday-Friday: develop and record your pitch

1 — PITCH DECK

1. CONTEXT

WHAT IS THE SETTING,
WHAT'S HAPPENING, OTHER
FACTS

SETTING

2. PROBLEM

WHAT IS THE PROBLEM
YOU ARE SOLVING?

OPPORTUNITY

3. AUDIENCE

WHO IS EXPERIENCING THE
PROBLEM? WHAT ARE THEIR
ISSUES? WHO ELSE IS
INVOLVED?

USER(S)

4. GOALS AND IMPACT

WHAT NEEDS ARE YOU
SOLVING FOR

MISSION

5. VALUE

WHAT WILL THE KEY
BENEFITS BE TO SOLVE
THE ISSUE?

IMPACT

STORY STYLE

Check you have your story elements



STARTERS

Think about how you want to start your story. Here are some examples...

Anecdote

My mother use
to spend all her
time doing X

Imagine

What would happen
if you got married
to AI?

Connection

We all find taxes
boring and hard
to do...

What if...

We could make
privacy automatic
and easy?

Data

There are 94%
of people without
power

Drama

We have to change
before its too late

THE HOOK

Start with a strong opening to get your audience hooked, it should be memorable, meaningful and engaging.

EXAMPLE

The world is ending...
(drama)

Abby has a problem...
Personal

95% people hate icecream
(statistics)

Many of us are depressed
(emotion)

QUALITIES

DRAMATIC

PERSONAL

EMOTIONAL

ALARMING

INSIGHTFUL

HOPE

MISSING

MY HOOK?

4x weekly sprints until you reach the final presentation

